

The Living Ancient Economy

The conception of the ancient economy has long been fiercely debated. Within these academic exchanges, historian Moses Finley emerged as the most influential scholar of Classical economies in the second half of the twentieth century (Manning 8). Finley, a master of utilizing social relations as analytical tools, argued that there was no such thing as the ancient economy. His landmark work, *The Ancient Economy*, viewed ancient society, restricted to ancient Greece and Rome, as a static world where no price-setting market existed. Though Finley helped to move scholarship away from the primitive-modern framework through his innovative work with social sciences, Yale Classics professor Joseph Manning calls for a new analysis of the ancient economy (Manning 12, 16). A lot has changed since Finley's time: economics has evolved significantly, and new types of evidence, which Finley did not have access to, have emerged (Manning 9). Manning's *The Open Sea* argues for the inclusion of these new trends to expand from Finley's analysis into a more dynamic model. Classicists Peregrine Horden and Nicholas Purcell's *The Corrupting Sea*, a work exploring the history of the relationship between humans and the environment in the Mediterranean, adds to the constantly evolving study of the ancient economy. Horden and Purcell embrace Manning's call to integrate more kinds of evidence in creating a dynamic model of the ancient world. However, their emphasis on an ecologizing approach and micro-analysis of the Mediterranean may lead historians away from a true account of the ancient economy.

The Corrupting Sea reinforces the need to integrate more kinds of evidence to understand the ancient economy. Many of the shortcomings in Finley's account of the ancient economy came from the lack of evidence he utilized. With a focus on the elites and a reliance on a few literary sources, Finley could not paint a full picture of the ancient world (Manning 14). In *The*

Open Sea, Manning embraces the new wave of information coming into play: “Taking into account time, institutional change, and geospatial variability is crucial” (Manning 20). These new sources can help create a more robust model of economies, which itself is changing. As Manning states, “Economics is evolving extremely rapidly, embracing many new approaches... Economics has moved far beyond analysis of markets” (Manning 25). Rather than Finley’s rigid definition of “conglomeration of interdependent markets,” Manning proposes a more dynamic understanding of the ancient economy (Finley 22). Horden and Purcell’s investigation in the Mediterranean pushes even more for integrating new sources of evidence: “Thirdly, therefore, no limits must be set in advance to the kinds of evidence and topic that will be admissible” (Horden and Purcell 48). Just like Manning, they call for an integration, a blurring between different kinds of research. Their case study of Shlomo Dov Goitein’s work clearly shows the ability of new evidence to “transform our image of a period” and to alert “us to the possibility that our ideas about other centuries might be as mistaken” (Horden and Purcell 34).

There is great potential in unlocking new understandings of the ancient economy with a wider set of sources; however, there must still be caution in integrating these new pieces of evidence. Though Finley was too selective in the sources he used, he was right in needing to be skeptical. In *The Ancient Economy*, Finley states the biases from sources such as Thucydides in historical reports (Finley 24). He regrets the lack of quantifiable evidence from the ancient world, but also warns against incorrectly applying data: “We shall also see the dangers... They [ancient historians] are beginning to claim quantitative proof where the evidence does not warrant it, or to misjudge the implications” (Finley 25). Furthermore, he advises proceeding with caution to apply seemingly good evidence into their decision-making of the ancients: “There is the further danger, when we have succeeded in producing a good set of figures, of then imputing

that knowledge to the ancients themselves as an important component in their choices and decisions.” (25) As new information comes in, it will be even more tempting to include them to create a narrative of the seemingly elusive ancient economy. However, with these new possibilities, even more attention to detail and critical thinking will be required to accurately understand the ancient economy.

Out of all the new ways to understand ancient history, Horden and Purcell push for an ecologizing approach the most. They present the idea of studying the history *of* rather than the history *in* the Mediterranean (Horden and Purcell 9). They state the importance of observing the environment and the ways in which societies interact with the environment when analyzing history. This aligns with Manning advocating for historically unused sources: “Environment, geography, and climate change were critically important factors in comparative premodern economic performance” (Manning 30). Horden and Purcell contrast this ecologizing approach with the interactionist view, which emphasizes the exchange of goods.

While the environment is undoubtedly relevant to society, making it the primary lens for historical study may distort our understanding of the ancient economy. Horden and Purcell’s strong preference for the ecologizing approach risks overshadowing other important factors. They are quick to dismiss analyses that do not include environmental factors; they criticize the interactionist view because they “neglect ecology, the indispensable context of interaction” (Horden and Purcell 35). For similar reasons, they call Rostovtzeff’s analysis “mistaken” (Horden and Purcell 33). By dividing the historical analysis between history *of* and history *in*, Horden and Purcell take away the possible nuance of the ecologizing approach. They present ecology as an absolutely necessary part of historical analysis rather than a part of it. While Finley disregarded the environment as a source of understanding the ancient economy, it is dangerous to

take the completely opposite side to make it the foundation of understanding ancient society.

Though Manning acknowledges many new kinds of evidence emerging to help better understand the ancient economy, he does not push for one as the main source of evidence; rather, he calls for a thoughtful integration of all of them. Horden and Purcell go as far as to say that an analysis without considering the environment will yield no meaningful insight into the ancient world:

But without sustained attention to what is distinctively historical about the place of humanity within the environment, and particularly to the complexity of human interaction across large distances, the study of the Mediterranean past will ultimately not have advanced very far beyond Plato's simile of the frogs round a pond. (Horden and Purcell 49)

Though environmental analysis certainly adds more nuance to understanding ancient societies, it should not become the driving source of evidence.

Horden and Purcell push for a micro-analysis of the ancient world; they argue that the only way to get the full picture of the Mediterranean is by looking at regions individually. The Mediterranean was a paradox between an “all-too-apparent fragmentation” that could “unite the sea and its coastlands in a way far exceeding anything predicable of a continent” (Horden and Purcell 24). Though Finley did not believe there was a system of markets due to high costs of transportation, the “ease of communications” of the sea far surpassed land communications, making it, in fact, a valuable source of exchange (Horden and Purcell 10). However, instead of using the Mediterranean Sea’s unifying features, Horden and Purcell choose to look at the differences within the region: “Rather than treat physical characteristics one by one at greater length, or tease out common rhythms of history, we shall emphasize pronounced local irregularity” (13). For them, they avoid generalities, wanting “to address specific questions, and therefore to gather evidence selectively—from a limited range of periods and places” (Horden and Purcell 44). Though Finley’s view into the ancient economy was rather narrow, only ranging from 1000 BCE to 500 AD and focusing just on the Graeco-Roman world, he looked at it as a

whole (Finley 29). Despite downplaying the cultural and material exchanges that did happen in the ancient world, Finley did consider it as a unit; most notably, he omitted the Hellenistic era for “the center had shifted east” (Manning 13). In contrast, though Horden and Purcell look at the Mediterranean through a much wider timeline of 3000 years, their unit of analysis is significantly smaller.

Focusing too much on local differences, as Horden and Purcell do, can undermine efforts to construct a unified concept of the ancient economy. Rather than constructing the ancient economy, Horden and Purcell may portray the ancient economies, where there exists no commonality or relationships between them. In fact, Finley decided not to include the Near East and Egypt in the ancient economy for these reasons:

Were I to define “ancient” to embrace both worlds, there is not a single topic I could discuss without resorting to disconnected sections, employing different concepts and models. The exclusion of the Near East is therefore not arbitrary, though retention of the label “ancient” is frankly less easy to defend than on grounds of tradition and convenience. (Finley 28)

However, as Manning points out, the Mediterranean Sea played a crucial role in cross-cultural exchange, connecting civilizations from a wide range (Manning 35). Because of this unification, Manning argues to include the Near East and Egypt in a better understanding of the ancient economy. In his search to build a theory of economic history, Manning now sees more viable building blocks to achieve that dream: “We can build on Weber’s and Finley’s desire to develop a theory that is specific to time and place... An examination of the wide range of societies that inhabited the Mediterranean world shows us that there were a variety of solutions to economic problems” (Manning 37). Manning stands in the middle ground between Finley’s rejection of civilizations outside the Graeco-Roman world and Horden and Purcell’s insistence on micro-analysis. By embracing a wide range of economies with narrow lenses that build up to a greater unified theory, we can get a detailed, full picture of the ancient economy. Of course, we should

be careful of generalizations, but we should also look for the commonalities and relationships between different systems.

The conception of the ancient economy is constantly changing. Though history is the study of the past, it is alive, adapting to developments in the present. Horden and Purcell's *The Corrupting Sea* continues the discussion of the ancient economy that Finley and Manning engaged in. Horden and Purcell's openness to new forms of evidence reaffirms the need for a dynamic model of the ancient economy. However, by focusing too much on the environment, they run the risk of overlooking other important pieces of evidence. In advocating for a micro-analysis of ancient history, they introduce the danger of creating a fragmented account of the ancient economy. To get the most accurate conception of the ancient economy, we must incorporate all the new kinds of evidence that Manning, Horden, and Purcell have introduced, but with the skepticism that Finley had. The story of the ancient economy is unfolding before us, but we must be careful with how to tell it.

Bibliography

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